



UNPOISON

EARTH • AIR • WATER

The City Manager
City of Cape Town 2026/27 IDP/Budget
Podium Civic Centre, Cape Town 8001
VIA: budget.comments@capetown.gov.za
DATE: 30 April 2026

RE: UnPoison Comment on 2026/27 Draft Budget (CTA56/2026) - Request for Manual Weeding to be added to City's Budget, blanket herbicide spraying to stop

About UnPoison SA

UnPoison is a civil society movement and advocacy NPO focused on policy and regulatory reform of the legislative framework governing the use of agrochemicals and pesticides at a local, provincial, national and regional level.

At a local government level, this includes advocacy against the routine application of toxic herbicides and pesticides on public land in residential areas and sensitive ecological areas.

This submission is based on direct review of Annexures 21, 22, 24, 33, and 34 of the 2026/27 Draft Budget and the public participation advertisement published 31 March 2026 with the deadline of 16:30, 30th April 2026.

Every budget reference below is traceable to a specific line item, project code, page number, and rand value in those documents.

1. COMMENT ON THE OVERALL 2026/27 DRAFT BUDGET

There is a fundamental contradiction between the City's stated job creation, environmental, biodiversity, and public health objectives, and its ongoing operational practices. Rectifying this is critical in a city as ecologically significant and water-constrained as Cape Town. The comments that follow document that contradiction in detail, using line items confirmed in this budget.

1.1 What the budget confirms about toxic herbicide use

Across Cape Town, routine herbicide spraying occurs twice annually across approximately 10,000 km of roads, including verges, stormwater systems, parks, and residential areas. This programme involves the repeated blanket application of herbicides in the very spaces where residents live, children play, and critical biodiversity persists.

Annexure 34, the Demand (Procurement) Plan, **confirms this is a budgeted, planned activity for 2026/27.** Page 11 of 11 lists:

Tender 018G/2025/26 — "Supply and delivery of herbicides, pesticides, insecticides and organic & in-organic fertilizers for the City of Cape Town."

Three further operational line items carry direct chemical vegetation management spend:

SPX.0000162 "Weed Spraying Subcouncil 1" R435,000, 2026/27. Confirmed in both Annexure 24 (Draft Operating Subcouncil Allocation Projects, page 1 of 6) and Annexure 21 (Detailed Draft Operational Projects, MBRR Table SA38, page 74 of 107).

WPX.0015719 "Zoarvlei Cleaning & Clearing" R60,000. Department: Environmental Management. Annexure 22, page 6 of 52, Ward 55. Zoarvlei is a wetland. This line contains no specification that toxic chemical methods are excluded.

Five active landscape and grounds maintenance tenders in Annexure 34 DP9338Q/2025/26 (page 1), DP9202Q/2025/26 (page 1), 297Q/2024/25 (page 3), 131S/2025/26 (page 7), and 124S/2025/26 (page 7) cover work that routinely includes chemical vegetation management, with none specifying pesticide-free methods.

1.2 Why this matters

A major scientific review by the Stockholm Resilience Centre, "Planetary Health Check 2025", shows that seven of nine planetary boundaries have now been exceeded. A breached planetary boundary means that the planet cannot remediate itself, and the problem is compounded year on year. The category of Novel Entities which pesticides make up a major component of, is by far the most severe breach eroding planetary health.

BREACHED PLANETARY BOUNDARY FOR CHEMICAL CONTAMINATION

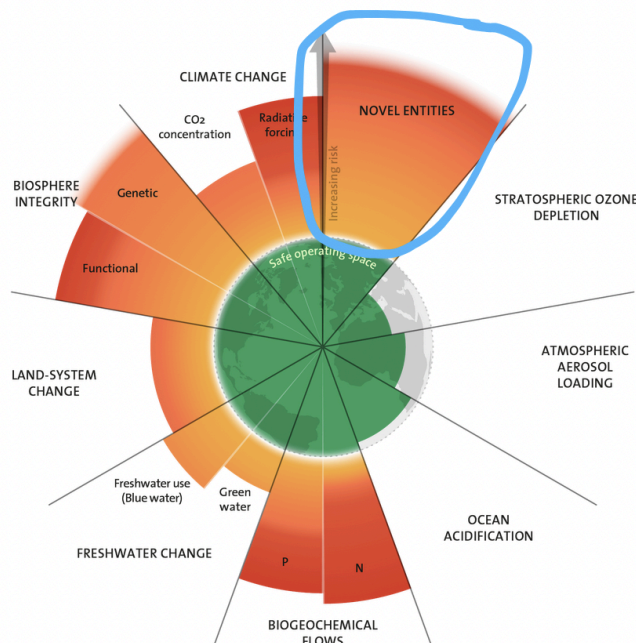


Figure 1: Stockholm Resilience Institute, Planetary Boundary Graphic, 2025

Cape Town is a globally unique city in ways that make this operational practice implausible to justify:

- It is the most biodiverse city in the world.
- It directly borders and envelops Table Mountain National Park, one of the seven wonders of the world
- It contains over 360 bird species, 83 mammalian species, 27 amphibian species, 2000 indigenous plant species and rich faunal diversity.
- It is interwoven with fourteen rivers and ten wetlands, and is a designated Ramsar Wetland City.

Herbicide use introduces toxic substances into these systems through runoff, (where sensitive endemic species are already under threat, some critically endangered), where they persist and bioaccumulate in water, sediment, and ecosystems.

Some herbicides used in municipal programmes fall within the category of Highly Hazardous Pesticides, a class that the WHO and FAO are working to phase out globally. All of the active ingredients used by CoCT are proven environmental toxicants, with some also proven to be harmful to human health in both acute and chronic exposure settings, including substances associated with carcinogenic, mutagenic, and reproductive health impacts.

Residents in Cape Town complain of asthma, respiratory conditions, and skin irritations after spraying, and there have been many reports of illness affecting pets. Repeat exposure over time is dangerous and can be responsible for many irreversible chronic illnesses like cancer, parkinsons, and non-hodgkins lymphoma.

What is alarming is that health and safety risk assessments on products only require the active ingredient be tested for safety, but not the entire formulation which is made of multiple ingredients including co-formulants and adjuvants. These can make the formulation 1000's of times more toxic.

Formulations are not tested for public health and safety, nor are spray schedules that require the mixing of multiple products, like the City prescribes in its tender. **Mixtures where combined toxicity has never been assessed for health and safety are sprayed into our residential environments and we are guinea pigs in a real life science experiment without consent.**

These are also applied within proximity to schools, homes, and play spaces, mostly without prior notification to adjacent residents or affected stakeholders.

At the same time, this approach displaces labour in a city facing high unemployment. Manual vegetation management requires workers. Chemical spraying does not.

This represents a gross misalignment between:

- infrastructure investment and environmental protection
- public safety commitments and chemical exposure
- biodiversity goals and operational practice

1.3 The alternative is already in this budget

Annexure 24 allocates Green Jobs environmental management funding across eight subcouncils in 2026/27:

Subcouncil	Project	Code	2026/27 Budget
SC 5	Green Jobs – Subcouncil 5	SPX.0004834	R1,995,000
SC 10	Green Jobs – Subcouncil 10	SPX.0004411	R1,000,000
SC 13	Green Jobs – Subcouncil 13	SPX.0004388	R1,195,000
SC 14	Green Jobs – Wards 16, 19 & 108	SPX.0003491	R1,995,000
SC 15	Green Jobs – Subcouncil 15	SPX.0004852	R1,995,000
SC 16	Green Jobs – Subcouncil 16	SPX.0004853	R1,995,000
SC 19	Green Jobs – Subcouncil 19	SPX.0004389	R1,995,000
SC 18	Green Jobs – Ward 72	SPX.0004854	R332,500
TOTAL			≈ R12,502,500

Source: Annexure 24, Draft Operating Subcouncil Allocation Projects, pages 2-6.

Annexure 34 (page 11) further includes Tender 014S/2025/26: "Implementation of labour intensive interventions to restore and rehabilitate natural ecosystems (ecological infrastructures) Green Jobs projects." This is a city-wide procurement item for labour-based ecological management.

The City is spending over R12 million on labour-based ecological management in the same budget that funds chemical weed spraying. These approaches address the same public spaces. The budget offers no rationale for running them in parallel.

Manual, non-chemical weed control and vegetation management is already widely implemented across hundreds of cities and towns in the UK and EU. These methods are effective, scalable, and align directly with Cape Town's own stated objective of job creation through the Expanded Public Works Programme (EPWP) and conservation stewardship initiatives. This is not an experimental approach. Manual, non-chemical weed control is widely implemented across the UK, with more than 70 local authorities, including Westminster, Lambeth, and Bath that have banned or phased out chemical herbicides on public land. These methods are proven at scale, and align directly with Cape Town's own stated objective of job creation through the Expanded Public Works Programme (EPWP).

There is a clear and practical alternative: stop blanket herbicide spraying, introduce manual weeding as a formal budget line item, and implement this approach at ward level. This would transform a current point of contradiction into an opportunity to deliver on job creation, public health, environmental protection, and inclusive economic development simultaneously.

1.4 The performance framework is silent on all of this

Annexure 33 (Measurable Performance Objectives, MBRR Table SA7) sets the City's 2026/27 KPIs. Four are directly relevant:

KPI 9.A / ENV4.21 (pages 2 and 6 of 11) Target: 65.5% of biodiversity priority areas protected. The City proclaims protection of nearly two-thirds of its biodiversity priority land while simultaneously funding herbicide procurement and clearing operations with no chemical exclusion zones.

KPI 4.B (page 1 of 11) Target: 99% of drinking water samples complying with SANS241. SANS241 does not test for herbicide or pesticide residues. Compliance with this standard does not indicate that the water is free of herbicide contamination.

KPI ENV5.21 (page 5 of 11) Target: 2,300 inland water samples. No herbicide or pesticide parameters are specified. Given that herbicides are applied on land directly adjacent to many of the City's rivers and wetlands, the absence of herbicide monitoring in this programme is a gap the 2026/27 budget does not address.

KPI 11.A (page 2 of 11) Target: 90% of Recreation and Parks open space mowed per annual plan. Parks management is measured by mowing frequency alone. There is no KPI for pesticide-free maintenance, no chemical use reduction target, and no community health monitoring near spray zones.

The result: the City has no instrument to detect whether its herbicide programme is contaminating its own water systems, and no performance incentive to move away from it.

1.5 What residents say

UnPoison conducted a community poll across 101 Cape Town suburbs with 1,176 respondents. 98.6% supported manual, poison-free weeding as the preferred method for public space maintenance. 33.8% were unaware that herbicides were being applied in their public spaces before participating. A full breakdown of the results is set out on the next page.



Figure 2: UnPoison SA Community Poll results, October 2025 to March 2026. 1,176 respondents across 101 Cape Town suburbs.

The second figure matters as much as the first. It indicates both strong public support for change, and a lack of transparency in current practice. Routine discharge of toxic herbicides into our suburbs, parks, and waterways without community awareness or consent.

Twelve Cape Town suburbs, Capri, Clovelly, Kirstenhof, Lakeside, Misty Cliffs, Muizenberg MID, Noordhoek, Scarborough, Tokai, Westlake, Zeekoevlei, and Zwaansyk, have already secured formal spray exemptions through community led objection initiatives taking responsibility for their own weeding, each supported by their ward councillors.

Residents should not have to bear the additional cost and time burden of poison-free weed control to keep their families and communities safe from exposure. This should be administered by the city with a budget diverted from toxic pesticide procurement and application.

1.6 Recommendations

UnPoison recommends that the City align its operational expenditure with its strategic goals by:

- Stopping blanket herbicide spraying and introducing manual weeding as a formal budget line item.
- Disclosing the full scope of herbicide and pesticide use under Tender 018G/2025/26 and landscape maintenance contracts DP9338Q/2025/26, DP9202Q/2025/26, 297Q/2024/25, 1315/2025/26, and

124S/2025/26 (all Annexure 34), including which products are used, in which areas, and with what notification to adjacent residents. **We have a right to know and pesticide application by law requires those affected to be notified with full details.**

- (c) Amending the scope of the above maintenance contracts to explicitly prohibit herbicide and pesticide application in publicly accessible spaces, and to require a 50-metre chemical-free buffer around creches, schools, wetlands, watercourses, and biodiversity priority areas.
- (d) Redirecting the Weed Spraying budget (Project SPX.0000162, R435,000, confirmed in Annexure 24, page 1 and Annexure 21, page 74) to manual vegetation management, consistent with the Green Jobs approach already funded across eight subcouncils in this budget.
- (e) Adding herbicide and pesticide residue parameters, including glyphosate and AMPA, to the inland and coastal water sampling programmes (KPIs ENV5.21 and ENV5.12, Annexure 33, page 6).
- (f) Adding a pesticide-free open space management KPI to the 2026/27 performance scorecard alongside the existing parks mowing KPI (KPI 11.A, Annexure 33, page 2).

1.7 UnPoison's Goals for The City of Cape Town - for the record.

- By end of 2027 - Metro wide poison-free weed control and total phase out Highly Hazardous Pesticides in CoCT
- By 2030 - CoCT to become a pesticide-free city

2. COMMENT ON RATES AND TARIFFS (ANNEXURE 6)

There is a growing expectation that increased tariffs should translate into improvements not only in long-term infrastructure, but also in the quality and safety of everyday environments. Currently, tariff-funded services continue to support operational practices (such as widespread herbicide spraying) that undermine the City's own investments in water quality, biodiversity, and public health.

Residents are therefore effectively funding:

- infrastructure aimed at environmental protection;
- while simultaneously funding practices that introduce hazardous chemical pollutants into those same systems, practices that irreversibly decrease biodiversity, degrade the environment, decimate protected ecosystems, and chronically impact public health

This disconnect raises concerns about value, accountability, and alignment.

Furthermore, the tariff structure does not incentivise or support a transition toward safe, sustainable, labour-based service delivery models. This is a missed opportunity to use public expenditure to drive both environmental and socio-economic outcomes.

58 City Improvement Districts are authorised in this budget with combined additional rates allocations in the hundreds of millions (Draft Budget Advertisement, page 3): Camps Bay at R31.2 million, Cape Town Central City at R132.2 million, Sea Point at R11.3 million, Newlands at R7.75 million, among others. CIDs that maintain high-quality public environments could readily adopt a pesticide-free area designation. No such standard currently exists within the additional rates framework.

UnPoison SA recommends that the City:

- (a) Align tariff-funded operational expenditure with environmental and health objectives, and redirect a portion of current landscape maintenance spending toward manual weeding and non-chemical vegetation management.

- (b) Audit which landscape and grounds maintenance contracts funded through operating tariffs currently permit herbicide use, and publish the findings.
- (c) Develop a pesticide-free area designation for City Improvement Districts as an optional performance standard within the additional rates authorisation framework.
- (d) Ensure that tariff increases deliver visible improvements in community wellbeing, including the removal of hazardous chemicals from the public spaces residents use daily.

This would strengthen public trust and ensure that residents see tangible, local benefits from the costs they are being asked to bear.

3. COMMENT ON SUBCOUNCIL 1 & 19 WARD BUDGET ALLOCATIONS

Subcouncil 1 Wards 23, 29, 32 and 107 (Atlantis / Melkbosstrand / Parklands corridor)

Project SPX.0000162 "Weed Spraying - Subcouncil 1" is the only weed spraying line item with a confirmed 2026/27 budget in this document set. It carries R435,000 and covers all four wards in Subcouncil 1 collectively (Wards 23, 29, 32, and 107). The project is not attributed to a single ward; it is coded Ward 200, the City's generic placeholder for subcouncil-wide allocations, covering the Atlantis, Melkbosstrand, and Parklands corridor.

This budget line has a history that this budget reverses. Annexure 21 (page 77 of 107) records Project SPX.0003493, "Green Jobs - Subcouncil 1", with R700,000 in audited expenditure in 2023/24.

That project does not appear in the 2026/27 budget. The City has defunded the labour-based ecological management alternative in Subcouncil 1 while maintaining the chemical weed spraying programme. The 2026/27 budget continues the spraying. It does not continue the jobs.

Current herbicide spraying programmes are implemented uniformly across the city, including in residential areas, along pedestrian routes, and within proximity to schools, homes, and ecological systems. These are precisely the spaces where alternative approaches are both viable and desirable, and where the impact on residents is most direct.

UnPoison requests that the Ward Councillors for Wards 23, 29, 32 and 107, and the Subcouncil 1 committee:

- (a) Oppose the continuation of Project SPX.0000162 "Weed Spraying Subcouncil 1" (R435,000, Annexure 24 page 1, Annexure 21 page 74) and request that this allocation be redirected to manual, labour-intensive vegetation management.
- (b) Request the reinstatement of a Green Jobs ecological management allocation for Subcouncil 1, consistent with the allocations made to eight other subcouncils in this budget (Annexure 24, pages 1-6, total ≈ R12.5 million). In 2023/24, Subcouncil 1 spent R700,000 on exactly this (SPX.0003493, Annexure 21 page 77). There is no evident reason why it has been dropped.
- (c) Request prior community notification for any herbicide application within the subcouncil boundary while this reallocation is being processed.

Subcouncil 19 has a clear opportunity to lead by example

Annexure 24 (page 5 of 6) allocates R1,995,000 for "Green Jobs - Subcouncil 19" (SPX.0004389) under Environmental Management for 2026/27. This is a substantial, already-budgeted commitment to labour-based ecological work within the subcouncil.

For Subcouncil 19, which spans most of the Southern Peninsula with suburbs in and around the national park, there is a clear opportunity to lead by example through the prioritisation of manual, non-chemical vegetation management at ward level.

Current herbicide spraying programmes are implemented uniformly across the city, despite its proximity to protected ecosystems, as well as residential areas, pedestrian routes, and within proximity to schools, and homes.

This is precisely the subcouncil where alternative poison-free approaches are both viable and imperative.

The proximity of residential areas to natural systems increases the importance of reducing chemical exposure and protecting biodiversity at a local level.

Introducing manual weeding within the subcouncil's existing budget would:

- create local green jobs
- support small contractors and community-based initiatives
- improve the quality and visibility of maintenance
- reduce chemical exposure in public spaces
- align with the 2017 Environmental Strategy and the City's biodiversity and conservation stewardship goals

This approach directly supports the City's stated objective of job creation through EPWP and related programmes. It is not an untested concept. Suburbs within Subcouncil 19 are self-funding manual weeding and hundreds of cities and towns across the UK and EU have successfully transitioned away from pesticide and herbicide use, demonstrating that effective alternatives already exist.

UnPoison will gladly facilitate a learning exchange between CoCT officials and those successfully overseeing pesticide-free towns in the EU.

UnPoison recommends that Subcouncil 19:

- (a) Allocate funding for manual weeding as a pilot programme, directing existing Green Jobs funding (SPX.0004389, R1,995,000, Annexure 24 page 5) toward systematic replacement of herbicide spraying in residential areas and pedestrian corridors.
- (b) Eliminate blanket herbicide spraying entirely within the subcouncil boundary, with effect from 1 July 2026.
- (c) Monitor outcomes in terms of cost, employment, and community satisfaction, and report to the subcouncil committee at year end. UnPoison SA will support this evaluation.

This would position Subcouncil 19 as the first formally designated pesticide-free subcouncil in Cape Town. Given the community support **(98.6% of 1,176 residents polled across 101 suburbs in favour of manual weeding)**, it would be a popular decision.

Conclusion

UnPoison is available to provide supporting material for any point raised above, as well as strategic support from our academic and expert network.

We request that this submission be referred to each of the directorates responsible for the items cited: Environmental and Heritage Management, Recreation and Parks, Coastal Management, Supply Chain Management as well as Water and Sanitation.

Cape Town's long term sustainability, biodiversity and environmental goals, water systems, green jobs, and public health deserve operational practices that match the City's stated ambitions. This budget contains the funding mechanisms to begin that alignment. We urge the City to use them.



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Annexures reviewed in preparing this submission:

Annexure 21 - Detailed Draft Operational Projects (MBRR Table SA38), 107 pages

Annexure 22 - Draft Operating and Capital Ward Allocation Projects Supported by Subcouncils, 52 pages

Annexure 24 - Draft Operating Subcouncil Allocation Projects Supported by Subcouncils, 6 pages

Annexure 33 - Measurable Performance Objectives (MBRR Table SA7), 11 pages

Annexure 34 - City of Cape Town Demand (Procurement) Plan, 11 pages

Draft Budget 2026/27 Public Participation Advertisement (English)

City of Cape Town 2026/27 Draft Budget, tabled 31 March 2026 (CTA56/2026)